

A TITLE UP FOR GRABS

Ilia Topuria leaves the featherweight class following an **undefeated 2024 campaign.**

Nigamanth P

nigamanth.p@thehindu.co.in

Ultimate Fighting Championship CEO and president Dana White dropped a bombshell when he announced that reigning featherweight champion Ilia Topuria will be relinquishing the title.

Topuria's decision has opened the door to an exciting match-up between former divisional champion Alexander Volkanovski and Diego Lopes for the vacant title, making the 2025 calendar that much more engrossing.

"Topuria has felt like he's done all he can in that division, and he feels like he's cemented his legacy, and his body cannot make the weight anymore," White said in an *Instagram Live* video.

"So, he will move up to 155 pounds (lightweight) and vacate the featherweight title. As soon as the first punch is thrown in the Volkanovski vs. Lopes fight, the title is vacated," he added.

The Georgian-Spanish grappler leaves the featherweight class following an undefeated 2024 campaign. He defeated Volkanovski at UFC 298 to win the championship and then

defeated Max Holloway by knockout at UFC 308 to defend it.

Topuria has reportedly set his sights on the lightweight title and could face current champion Islam Makhachev. However, there has been no development on that front yet.

Volkanovski (**right inset**) and Lopes (**left inset**) will lock horns in Miami on April 12, marking Volkanovski's return to action after 14 months away following his knockout loss to Topuria.

The Great' seeks two-time champion status, and while most assumed that opportunity would come in a rematch against Topuria, Lopes boasts an impressive track record to make the fight a cut above the rest.

Lopes burst onto the scene in mid-2023, earning five wins in just over a year to catapult himself into the featherweight title picture. His most recent success came at UFC 306, where he secured a gruelling unanimous decision win against Brian Ortega.

On the other hand, Volkanovski has had a rather unceremonious couple of fights in the recent past, having lost two on the bounce by knockout and three of his last four. But his performance in the last couple of years does not paint the full picture of his calibre inside the ring.

Apart from Topuria, the only other fighter the 36-year-old Volkanovski has failed against was Makhachev before switching weight classes. He currently boasts an astounding 13-3 record in the UFC.

In addition to the featherweight title fight, there are two highly interesting fights. Firstly, Paddy 'The Baddy' Pimblett gets his toughest test when he meets former lightweight titleholder Michael Chandler.

The other bout will see former interim featherweight champion Yair Rodriguez welcoming newcomer Patricio 'Pitbull' Freire.

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